The Mind of Christ

Humility means looking to the interests of others, following Jesus who emptied himself and became obedient to death, whom God has exalted as Lord.

Main passage	Philippians 2:1-11 (KJV)
Topic	Humility
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Look to the interests of others	7 min
Teaching point 2: Have the mind of Christ, who humbled himself	7 min
Teaching point 3: God exalts the humble	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Who is the most humble person you have known? What made them humble?" Most answers will describe someone who served others, was not concerned with credit, and was genuinely interested in other people. Point out that humility is less about thinking poorly of yourself and more about thinking of yourself less.

Scripture (3 min)

Philippians 2:1-11

[1] If there be therefore any consolation in Christ, if any comfort of love, if any fellowship of the Spirit, if any bowels and mercies, [2] Fulfil ye my joy, that ye be likeminded, having the same love, being of one accord, of one mind. [3] Let nothing be done through strife or vainglory; but in lowliness of mind let each esteem other better than themselves. [4] Look not every man on his own things, but every man also on the things of others. [5] Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus: [6] Who, being in the form of God, thought it not

robbery to be equal with God: [7] But made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant, and was made in the likeness of men: [8] And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross. [9] Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name: [10] That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth; [11] And that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

Read the passage aloud. Verses 6-11 may have been an early Christian hymn; consider reading them more slowly.

Background (5 min)

Philippians is a warm letter to a church Paul loved, but there were tensions (see 4:2). In chapter 2 Paul appeals for unity, and he knows that unity depends on humility. Then he gives the greatest example there is: Jesus Christ.

Verses 6-11 describe a downward path and an upward path. Christ, who was in the form of God, emptied himself, took the form of a servant, became a man and died on a cross. Then God highly exalted him, and every knee will bow to him.

Teacher note: "Made himself of no reputation" (literally "emptied himself") does not mean Jesus stopped being God. Christians agree that he remained fully God while becoming fully man; he set aside his heavenly glory and privileges and took the humble place of a servant.

Teaching point 1: Look to the interests of others (7 min)

Paul asks the church to be of one mind. To do that they must stop acting from rivalry or vanity and instead "esteem other better than themselves." Humility is not denying our gifts. It is refusing to let our own concerns crowd out everyone else's.

Supporting verses

Philippians 2:1-4: If there be therefore any consolation in Christ, if any comfort of love, if any fellowship of the Spirit, if any bowels and mercies, Fulfil ye my joy, that ye be likeminded, having the same love, being of one accord, of one mind. Let nothing be done through strife or vainglory; but in lowliness of mind let each esteem other better than themselves. Look not every man on his own things, but every man also on the things of others.

Romans 12:10: Be kindly affectioned one to another with brotherly love; in honour preferring one another;

Galatians 5:13: For, brethren, ye have been called unto liberty; only use not liberty for an occasion to the flesh, but by love serve one another.

> *"This command forbids us to do anything, or attempt anything, as the mere result of strife."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:3

> *"That is, be not selfish. Do not let your care and attention be wholly absorbed by your own concerns, or by the concerns of your own family."*

— Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:4

Handout blanks (answers)

In lowliness of mind let each esteem other **better** than themselves.

Look not every man on his own things, but also on the things of **others**.

Teaching point 2: Have the mind of Christ, who humbled himself (7 min)

"Let this mind be in you" (v. 5). Jesus did not cling to his rights. He took the lowest place, a servant and then a criminal's death on a cross. If the Son of God was willing to stoop that far for us, we can stoop to serve one another.

Supporting verses

Philippians 2:5-8: Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus: Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God: But made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant, and was made in the likeness of men: And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross.

John 13:12-15: So after he had washed their feet, and had taken his garments, and was set down again, he said unto them, Know ye what I have done to you? Ye call me Master and Lord: and ye say well; for so I am. If I then, your Lord and Master, have washed your feet; ye also ought to wash one another's feet. For I have given you an example, that ye should do as I have done to you.

Mark 10:45: For even the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.

> *"The object of this reference to the example of the Saviour is particularly to enforce the duty of humility."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:5

> *"He emptied himself - did not appear in his glory, for he assumed the form of a servant, being made in the likeness of man."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Philippians 2:7

Handout blanks (answers)

Christ took upon him the form of a **servant**.

He became obedient unto death, even the death of the **cross**.

Teaching point 3: God exalts the humble (7 min)

The story does not end at the cross. "Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him" (v. 9). Every knee will bow, and every tongue will confess that Jesus Christ is Lord. The way up in God's kingdom is the way down. We can afford to be humble, because our honour is safe in God's hands.

Supporting verses

Philippians 2:9-11: Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name: That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth; And that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

James 4:10: Humble yourselves in the sight of the Lord, and he shall lift you up.

1 Peter 5:5-6: Likewise, ye younger, submit yourselves unto the elder. Yea, all of you be subject one to another, and be clothed with humility: for God resisteth the proud, and giveth grace to the humble. Humble yourselves therefore under the mighty hand of God, that he may exalt you in due time:

> *"The knee should bow, or bend, in token of honour, or worship; that is, all men should adore him."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:10

Handout blanks (answers)

God hath highly **exalted** him.

Every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is **Lord**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. How would you define humility in your own words?

Answers will vary; aim for something like "putting others' interests alongside or ahead of our own, because we trust God with our honour."

2. Why is humility necessary for unity in a church or a family?

Pride and rivalry divide; humility makes room for others, listens, and yields where it can.

3. What does Jesus' example show us about what humility costs?

It cost him his glory, comfort and life. Humility often means giving up rights, credit or convenience.

4. How does knowing that God exalts the humble free us to serve without recognition?

We do not have to fight for honour; God sees and will reward in his time.

Application (3 min)

Do one act of service this week that no one will notice or thank you for. In a conversation, try to ask more questions than you answer and focus on the other person's concerns. Pray verse 5 each morning: "Let this mind be in me, which was also in Christ Jesus."

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord Jesus, you were rich, yet for our sakes you became poor; you took the form of a servant and died on the cross. Forgive our pride and selfish ambition. Give us your mind, so that we look to the interests of others and serve one another in love. We bow before you and confess that you are Lord, to the glory of God the Father. Amen.

Sources quoted

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:3

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:4

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:5

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Philippians 2:7

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 2:10

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